Cinema vs. Steaming: A Comparative Study on Modern Viewing Habits

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Executive Summary

This essay explains how streaming services have changed movie-watching habits based on a survey of 137 people. While many people now watch movies at home, the study shows that movie theaters are still very important to "movieholics".

The survey found several key trends regarding how people choose between streaming and the cinema:

- Most people (83.9%) subscribe to Netflix, and about 25.5% watch streaming content every single day.
- Even with many streaming options, 65.7% of people still went to the cinema 5 or more times in the last six months.
- Watching at the cinema helps people focus much better; 62.8% felt "completely focused" at the theater, while only 2.3% felt that way while streaming at home.
- The most important reason people choose to go to the theater is the "Movie Genre" (42.97%), especially for films with big visual effects.
- A huge majority (84.7%) would still go to the theater specifically to get "exclusive promos" like posters or collectibles, even if the movie is available online.

To help theaters stay popular in the future, the report offers these simple suggestions:

- Theaters should focus on "Big-Screen" genres like Action or Sci-Fi that look better on a giant screen.
- Cinemas should work with movie studios to give out more high-quality physical gifts to make fans want to visit.
- Theaters could start a "Monthly Pass" with a flat fee to encourage loyal customers to visit more often, similar to how Netflix works.

In conclusion, while streaming is very convenient, the special atmosphere and focus provided by the cinema mean that people are not ready to give up the big screen yet.

Introduction

Statement of Purpose

As a subscriber to multiple streaming platforms and a movieholic, I think streaming services really changed my viewing habits. Sometimes I will wait for the movie to go on the streaming platform then watch it rather than watching in the cinema because I do not want to spend money on a certain film. But at the same time cinemas provide a lot of collectables of movies for people to go to the theater more. It altered my habits of watching movies. And I wonder if it is the same for most people.

Therefore, the purpose of this survey is to see if streaming platforms have changed people's viewing habits by comparing the frequency and level of focus between going to the theater and streaming usage. Using numeric data from neutral questions, it will be clear to see people's viewing habits. Eventually I can see if people tend to go to the cinema less, as well as come up with some ideas that can make a change to the current situation.

Background

In recent years, the rise of streaming platforms has changed how people watch movies. While this trend started a while ago, the COVID-19 pandemic made it much stronger. During the lockdowns, people were forced to stay home, and watching movies online became the main way to stay entertained.

Even though cinemas have reopened now, many people still ask themselves: 'Why should I spend money on a cinema ticket when I can just pay for a subscription and watch everything at home?' This change in mindset is a big challenge for movie theaters today. To understand how people feel about this, I conducted an online survey for three weeks and received a total of 137 responses. This study explores the competition between the big screen and the convenience of streaming services.

Discussion of Findings

Cinema Habits

The results showed that 65.7% of the respondents have gone to the cinema five or more times in the last six months, and only 2.9% of the respondents have not gone to the cinema once.

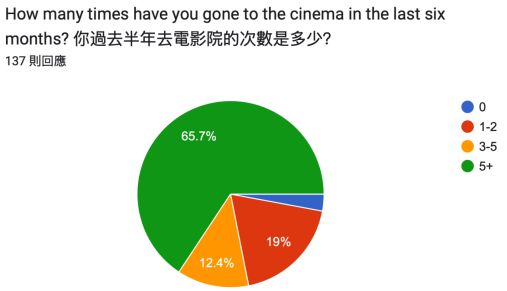

Figure 1

With most of the respondents thinking that going to the cinema will enhance their viewing experience, it also shows that the respondents have a high level of focus in the cinema.

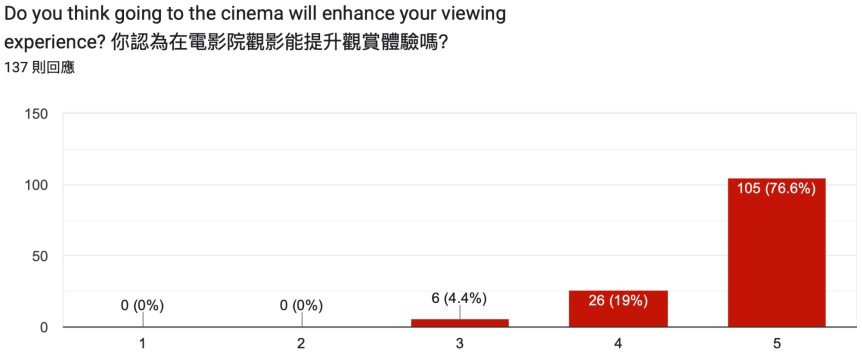

Figure 2 (5 for Strongly agree)

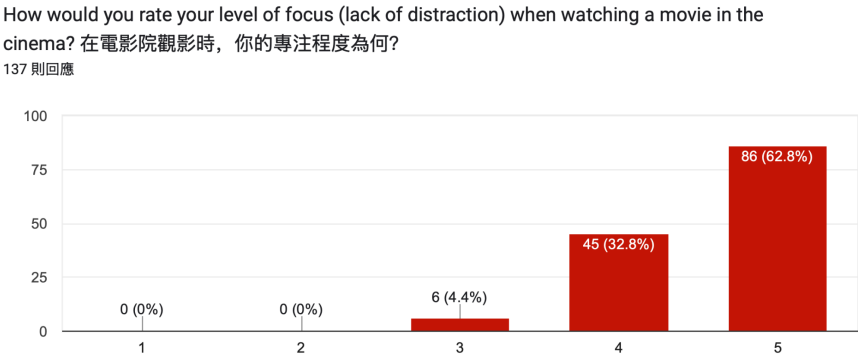

Figure 3 (5 for Completely focused)

Streaming Platfoms

The study found that only 7 respondents have not subscribed to any streaming platforms in the last six months. Compared to the global streaming market share, Netflix is without surprise the head of the industry. Over 83.9% of the respondents had subscribed to it. The second highest is Disney+, which 46.7% of the respondents had subscribed to. However, Prime Video is not as popular among the respondents as the global market. Surprisingly, Paramount+ got 0 subscribers while it has more subscribers than Apple TV+ in the global market. On the other hand, there are some platforms not mentioned in the questionnaire that still got bringed up. Some Chinese user based platforms like iQIYI, Tencent, Youku, and Taiwan based platforms such as MyVideo, Hami Video got mentioned by few people.

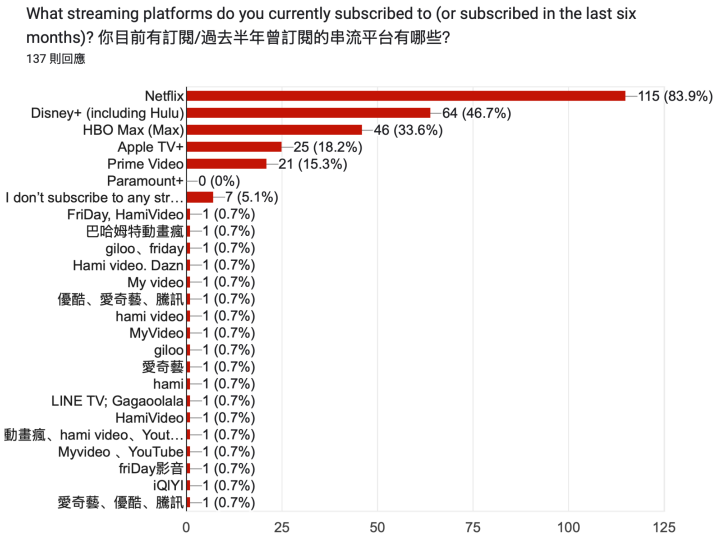

Figure 4

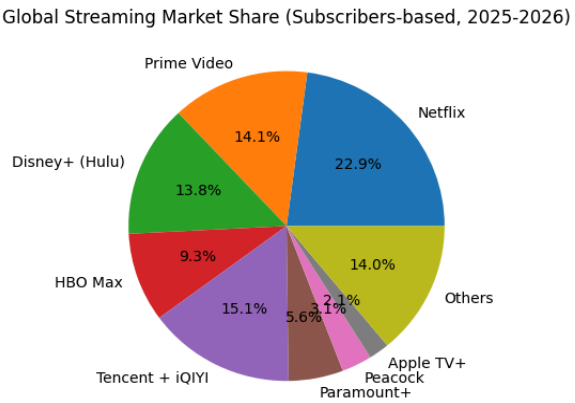

Figure 5 (Chart made by ChatGPT)

From the survey, we can see that about 1/4 of the respondents watch streaming platforms everyday. Only 20% of the respondents do not watch it every week.

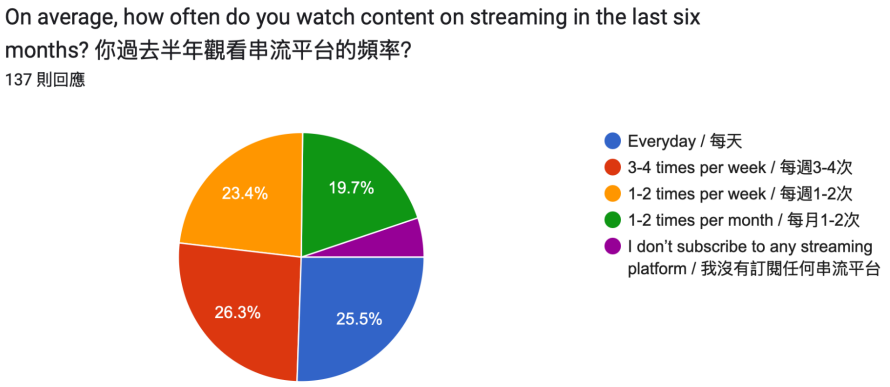

Figure 6

However, people tend to be more distracted watching on streaming platforms, with only 2.3% of respondents thinking that they are completely focused during a movie.

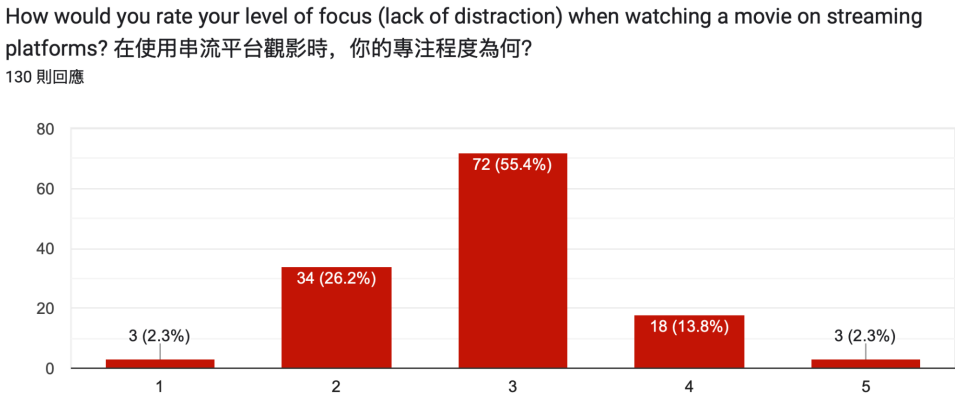

Figure 7 (5 for Completely focused)

Most of the respondents think that companies provide a substantial amount of content on streaming platforms. Only a few respondents are not satisfied with the selection.

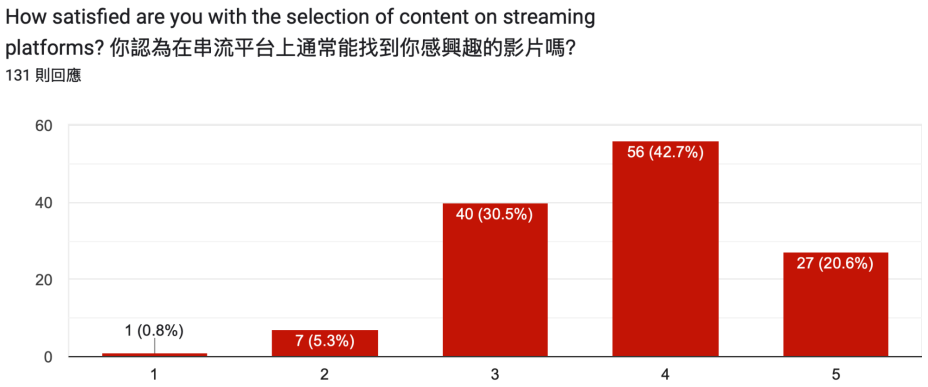

Figure 8 (5 for Extremely satisfied)

Overall Preference

70% of respondents think that they prefer to watch movies in the cinema, while 14% of them like to watch movies on streaming platforms.

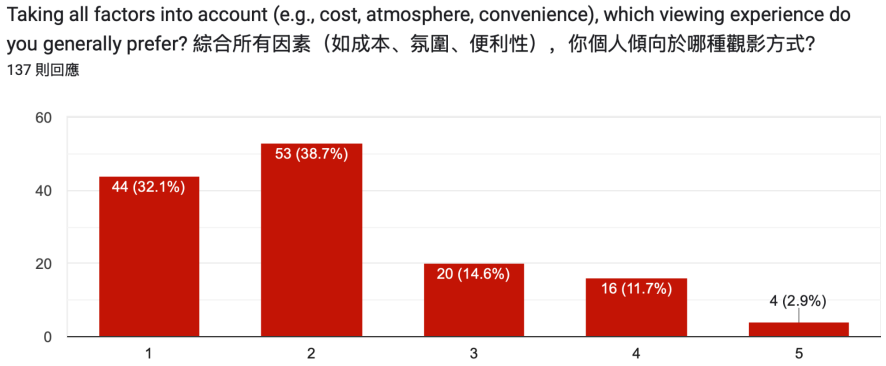

Figure 9 (5 for Watch on streaming platforms)

About 25% of the respondents think that there is no impact from streaming platforms, they still go to the cinema regularly. However, many respondents still think it decreased the frequency of going to the cinema.

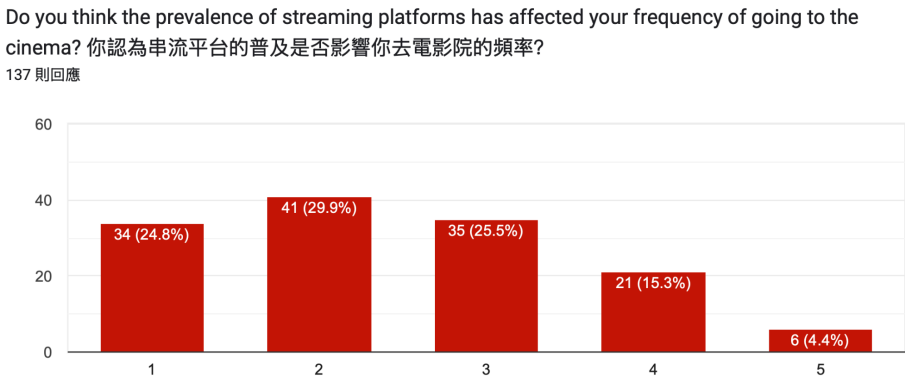

Figure 10 (5 for Significantly decreased)

What Draws People to Cinemas?

In the survey, I asked respondents what their primary considerations were when deciding to go to the cinema or watch a movie on streaming platforms. The most common response is movie genre, which about 43% of the respondents all said about it. The second is convenience, whether they are available at that time or they have the movie in the nearest cinema.

Types of Considerations	Times Mentioned	Percentage
Movie Genre & Interest	55	42.97%
Convenience, Time, & Location	36	28.12%
Audio-Visual Experience & Effects	21	16.41%
Economic Cost & Ticket Price	19	14.84%
Exclusive Promotional Items/Incentives	16	12.50%
Social Needs & Reviews	13	10.16%

Figure 11

Nowadays cinemas use a lot of exclusive promo to attract people to go to the theater. Therefore I asked them if they would still choose to see movies in the theater for exclusive promos even if they are available on streaming platforms. From the survey, only 15.3% of the respondents will stream it at home.

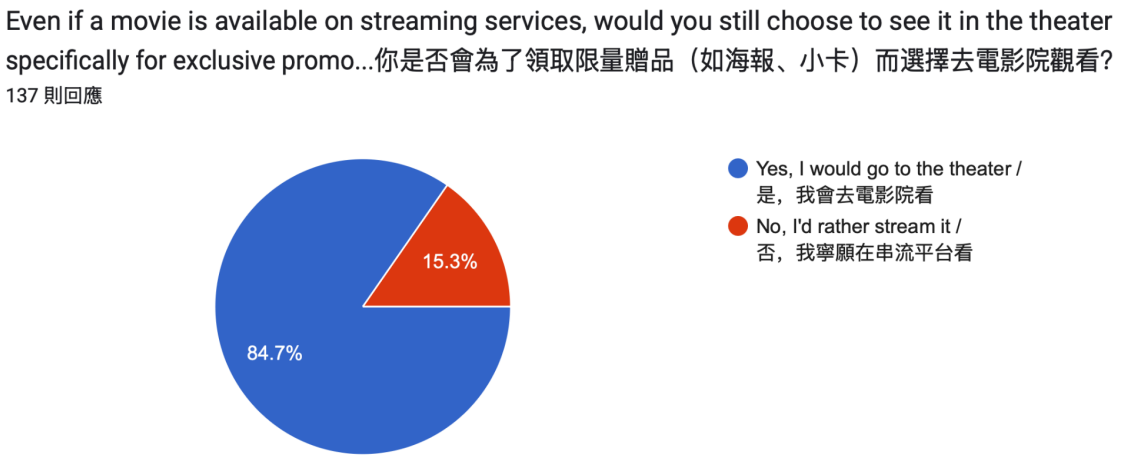

Figure 12

Conclusion & Recommendations

Conclusion

From the study, by comparing the frequency of people watching in cinemas and on streaming platforms, we can conclude that people still go to the theater while subscribing to streaming services. However, it does show that a significant amount of respondents have decreased their frequency to go to the cinema, since most of them are satisfied with the contents on streaming platforms. And they will choose if they are going to the cinema mostly based on the genre of the movie.

Comparing the level of focus (figure 3 & 7), we can see that most of the respondents get distracted while watching on streaming platforms. But they tend to be more focused while watching in the cinema. This is a big factor for people to enjoy a movie since being distracted may mean missing some important plots in the movies. Therefore, watching movies in cinemas still has its benefits for people who want to fully get into movies.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are proposed for cinema operators and film distributors:

- **Prioritize "Big-Screen" Genres and Event-Based Programming**

Figure 11 shows that "Movie Genre" (42.97%) is the primary factor in deciding whether to visit a theater. Therefore theaters can prioritize scheduling films that maximize audio-visual impact (Action, Sci-Fi, Horror). While for smaller indie films or dramas that might otherwise be streamed, theaters could create "Event Screenings" such as Q&A sessions or themed nights to provide the "Social Needs" (10.16%) that streaming lacks.

- **Leverage High-Value Physical Collectibles**

Figure 12 shows that only 15.3% would stay home if exclusive promos are offered. Cinemas can deepen partnerships with studios to offer exclusive, high-quality physical incentives. By collaborating with distributors to develop high-quality, scarce, and highly desirable tangible goods that create "Fear Of Missing Out" (FOMO), theaters can effectively motivate hesitant viewers to prioritize the theatrical release.

- **Implementing a Monthly Pass System to Retain Frequent Viewers**

According to Figure 1, a significant 65.7% of respondents go to the cinema 5 or more times in six months. However, Figure 10 shows that streaming has already begun to decrease overall attendance frequency. To compete with the subscription models of Netflix and Disney+ (Figure 5), cinemas should introduce a Monthly Pass. By offering a flat monthly fee for unlimited or set screenings, theaters can transform a "one-time purchase" into a recurring habit. This model rewards the most loyal 65.7% of the audience and encourages them to choose the cinema over streaming whenever a new film is released.

References

[1] *Top Streaming Services by Subscribers*. (n.d.). Flix Patrol. https://flixpatrol.com/streaming-services/subscribers/

Appendices

Cinema Habits

- **How many times have you gone to the cinema in the last six months?**
  0
  1-2
  3-5
  5+

- **Do you think going to the cinema will enhance your viewing experience?**
  1 Strongly disagree
  5 Strongly agree

- **How would you rate your level of focus (lack of distraction) when watching a movie in the cinema?**
  1 Completely distracted
  5 Completely focused

Streaming Habits

- **What streaming platforms do you currently subscribe to(or subscribed in the last six months)?**
  Netflix
  Disney+ (including Hulu)
  HBO Max (Max)
  Apple TV+
  Prime Video
  Paramount+
  I don't subscribe to any streaming platform
  others:

- **On average, how often do you watch content on streaming in the last six months?**
  Everyday
  3-4 times per week
  1-2 times per week
  1-2 times per month
  I don't subscribe to any streaming platform

- **How would you rate your level of focus (lack of distraction) when watching a movie on streaming platforms?**

1 Completely distracted
5 Completely focused

- **How satisfied are you with the selection of content on streaming platforms?**
  1 Extremely dissatisfied
  5 Extremely satisfied

Overall Preference

- **Taking all factors into account (e.g., cost, atmosphere, convenience), which viewing experience do you generally prefer?**
  1 Go to the cinema
  5 Watch on streaming platforms

- **Do you think the prevalence of streaming platforms has affected your frequency of going to the cinema?**
  1 No impact at all
  5 Significantly decreased

- **When deciding between "going to the cinema" and "using a streaming platform" to watch a movie, what is your primary consideration? (e.g. movie genre, ticket price, social needs, time, etc.)**

- **Even if a movie is available on streaming services, would you still choose to see it in the theater specifically for exclusive promotional items (e.g., posters, collectibles)?**
  Yes, I would go to the theater
  No, I'd rather stream it

Quesionnaire Link: https://forms.gle/EP6GsYdJfYWbNRb8A